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DUD MISSILE: The Klub missile (bottom) was billed as the main strike weapon of the navy's fleet of Kilo class submarines

WAY OFF TARGET

The primary weapon of the navy's undersea arm repeatedly misfires, severely compromising defence preparedness and leaving a question mark on future acquisitions of the system

■ **By Sandeep Unnithan**

It was billed as the primary strike weapon of the Indian Navy's submarine arm—a lethal undersea missile which would pop out of water, streak over the waves before spitting out a supersonic dart armed with 250 kg of explosives to obliterate its target. Except, seven years since it was inducted into service, the Russian-built Klub sub-launched Anti-Ship Cruise Missile (ASCM) has never hit a target in Indian waters.

Several defence officials have revealed that in numerous test launches since its induction, the missile, fired from a submarine's torpedo tube, had harmlessly splashed down into the water like a dead duck. The non-performing missile, which seriously undermines naval defence preparedness, is the latest in

the litany of woes against Russia which includes a two-year delay in the refit of the aircraft carrier *Vikramaditya* and a demand for a 10 per cent cost escalation in defence deals.

According to the Stockholm International Peace Research Institute (SIPRI) database, India ordered 175 of these missiles for its warships and submarines in 1998 for roughly Rs 1,750 crore, receiving them between 2001 and 2006. The navy, however, has still

not broken its silence. "Sharing of information on performance or efficacy of such a weapon system would constitute a serious breach of security and is detrimental to national interest," said naval spokesperson Captain Vinay Garg. It is also silent on the crucial question as to why the glitch, detected a few years ago, has not yet been fixed. Seven of the navy's fleet of 10 Kilos have been equipped to fire the missile.

Cruise missiles are among the most lethal weapons of a submarine, because unlike torpedoes which have speeds of not more than 70 kmph, they travel at speeds of over 900 kmph. A submarine armed with a 200-km range missile can perform a 'sea denial' mission in a radius of 400-km. Pakistan acquired this capability in the 1980s when it retrofitted its undersea fleet with the US-supplied

